

# **Long Form Project - Game Design Documentation**

**Course Code:** DIGA3002A

**Assignment:** LFP Milestone 1

**Group Members:**

Gemma Ferguson (2653435)

Wilrich van Deventer (2801594)

Phemelo Tsogang (2543064)

**Group Number:** 5

\* Red stars indicate work that has been newly added or work that has been changed for this submission.

# **Table of Contents**

## **Game Research**

Brief Synopsis of Our Game

Cloned Games

## **Category and Subcategory Analysis**

## **Game Interrogation**

Core Game Question

Hypothesis

Detailed Hypothesis Explanation

Design Goals

Core Gameplay Loop

Systems and Mechanics

Gameplay Actions and Challenges

## **\* Design Process**

Milestone 1 Iterative Process

## **Bibliography**

# **Game Research**

## **Brief synopsis of Our Game**

Our game is a narrative driven puzzle game wherein the player must overcome a virus in their code. The narrative follows the player, who takes on the role of a game developer, playtesting their own game. This game features a tile based grid that players traverse to reach an end point. This end point will be blocked by obstacles that can be overcome through the mechanical switching to a new playable area or 'map'. You switch from the 'normal mode' map to the 'safe mode' map wherein the tile layout is similar, but obstacles are different. Movement made on the safe map is reflected on the normal map, and vice versa.

As the player moves through the map levels, they encounter The Virus. The Virus is the antagonist of the narrative and will 'corrupt' the map that the player is on. This is done through the changing of pathways, obstacles, map layouts, and mechanics. The player must try to destroy The Virus by completing the puzzles of the game and using the normal-to-safe switching to clear/navigate around all Virus changes .

## **Cloned Games**

The games, and their relevant mechanics, that our group took inspiration from are as follows:

- **The Silent Age - Time Travel Mechanic**

*The Silent Age* is a point-and-click mystery adventure game. Players take on the role of a janitor working at a secretive research corporation. The player discovers an extinction level threat within the corporation labs and is given a time machine to prevent this threat. Players use this time machine to toggle/move between the present (1972) and the post-apocalyptic future (2012) to solve logical inventory and obstacle puzzles in an attempt to change the future and prevent humanity's demise.

The time travel mechanic operates with the click of the time-machine and effectively puts the player in the exact position in the future as they would be in the past, and vice versa. Use of the time machine is finite and can only be recharged when the player exposes the time machine to sunlight (charge-dependent).

**How we will use this mechanic:** The charge-based time travel between two of the same points in time will be taken from *The Silent Age* and adapted for our own game. We will create a map switching mechanic wherein the player can switch from a 'normal' map to a 'safe' map. The player's location on the maps will be identical when switched, similar to what is seen in *The Silent Age*. Normal and safe maps will be similar in layout, but not identical. Any changes made on the safe map will reflect on the normal map.

Additionally, map switching will be accompanied by a visual change. For example, in *The Silent Age* when players go from past to future, the architecture of the location won't change, but the visuals will. See Figure 1 below. We will similarly keep the base layout of maps the same, but we will go from a modern style on the normal map to an outdated style on the safe map.

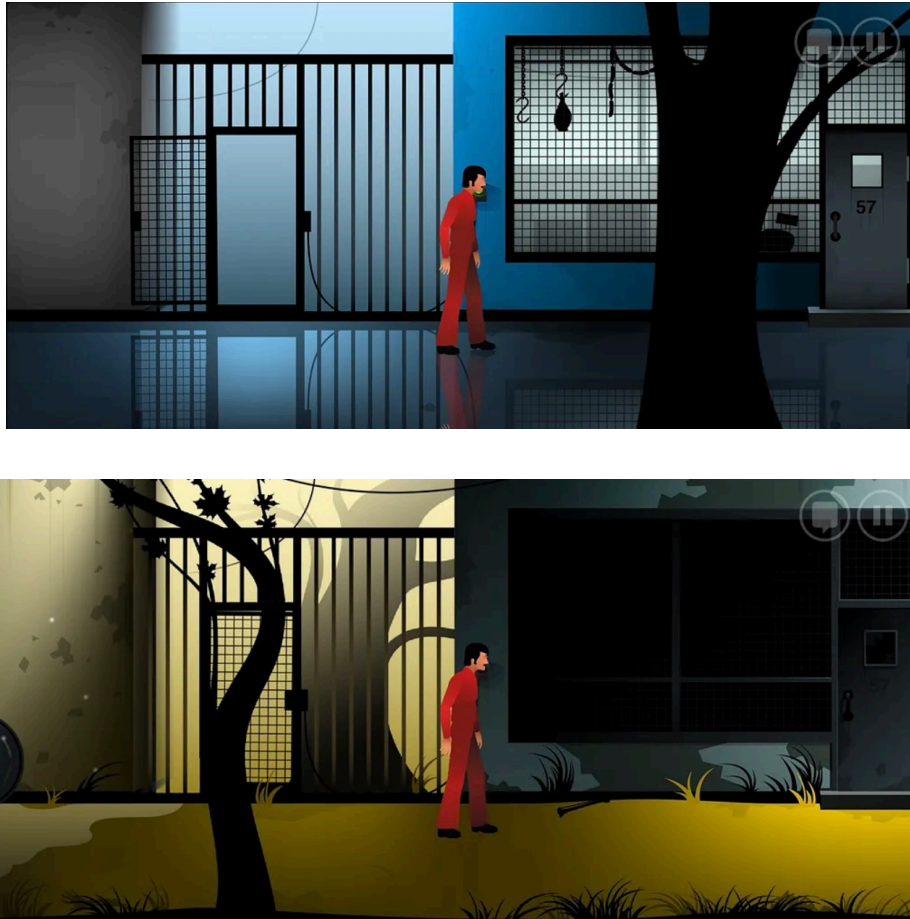


Figure 1: Still images from *The Silent Age* game (Allred 2012). The top screenshot features a prison in present/past time (1972). The bottom screenshot features the same prison in the future (2012). This is an example of the visual changes made to the same location when using the time machine mechanic.

- **There is No Game - Antagonistic Narrator**

*There is No Game: Wrong Dimension* is a meta, point-and-click comedy adventure game which heavily breaks the fourth wall. This is done through a title screen and sentient game narrator who repeatedly insists that there is no game and begs the player to stop playing and leave. Progress in the game involves ignoring the narrator, breaking UI and interacting with the environment. The entire experience heavily features the tension between the player taking action and the protesting/antagonistic narrator making their own actions and reacting to the player's actions.

**How we will use this mechanic:** We will be utilising the antagonistic narrator who acts as an active system that tries to hinder the player from progressing through the game. Our game will adapt the narrator's role by transforming them into The Virus, a system and narrator who actively changes the player's game by manipulating the tile-based puzzles and environment that the player is trying to solve. This will mirror *There is No Game*'s narrator by having the Virus speak to the player and telling them what not to do. The player will then rebel against these instructions, causing The Virus to speak out and act against the player. This "acting out" will be in the form of the Virus adding extra obstacles to the puzzle, changing puzzle solutions and constantly forcing the player to think about how the map switch mechanic can manipulate the Virus to their advantage to solve the puzzle.

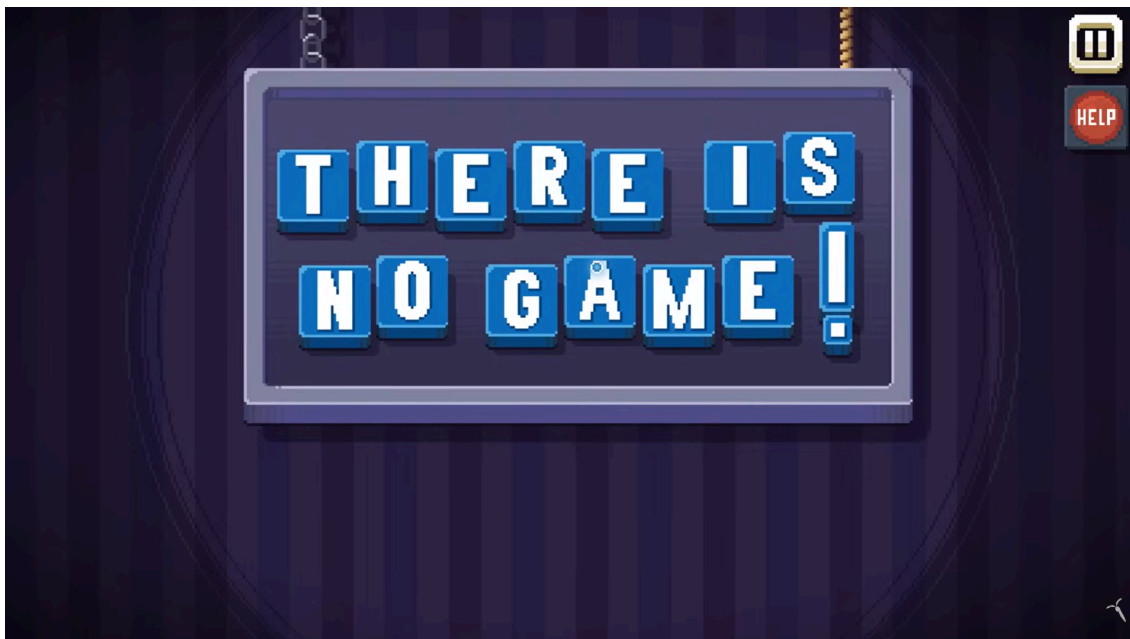




Figure 2: Still images from *There is no Game: Wrong Dimension*. The first image shows the title screen which the narrator says cannot be interacted with. The second image shows the player, ignoring the narrator and interacting with the game title letters which turns the “solution” of the puzzle into a game of *Brick Breaker*.

## Category and Subcategory Analysis

The games used as inspiration for this project primarily fall within the **adventure** genre, with subtle **puzzle** genre elements. While both *The Silent Age* and *There Is No Game: Wrong Dimension* are classified primarily as adventure games, they use puzzle-solving as an important method of progressing through their narratives. The game being developed takes inspiration from both of these games but places a greater emphasis on puzzle-solving as its primary form of gameplay through the tile-based environment.

### ***The Silent Age***

**Genre:** Mystery Adventure

**Sub-Genre/Elements:** Point-and-Click Puzzle Adventure

*The Silent Age* can be classified primarily as an **adventure game**, as its gameplay focuses on exploration, interacting with the environment, discovering information and progressing through a

narrative. The player controls the protagonist through different environments and must interact with objects and characters to uncover the story. The game can further be described as a **point-and-click puzzle adventure**, as progression frequently requires the player to identify relationships between objects, environments and events in order to overcome obstacles.

The game's time-travel mechanic is particularly important to its puzzle elements. The player can switch between two versions of the same environment, with differences between the two time periods allowing the player to solve environmental puzzles. Therefore, the adventure genre provides the narrative and exploration framework, while the puzzle elements provide the primary method of interacting with and progressing through the environment.

### ***There Is No Game: Wrong Dimension***

**Genre:** Comedy Adventure

**Sub-Genre/Elements:** Point-and-Click Puzzle, Meta-Fiction

*There Is No Game: Wrong Dimension* can also be classified as a “**comedic**” **adventure game**, as the player progresses through a series of environments by interacting with objects, solving problems and uncovering the game's narrative. Its gameplay is heavily based around **puzzle-solving**, with the player required to experiment with the environment and identify unconventional solutions to progress.

The game also contains strong **meta-fictional** elements, as it directly acknowledges the player's presence and breaks the conventional boundary between the player, narrator and the game. The narrator is aware of the player's actions and actively attempts to prevent them from progressing (see figure 2). This relationship between the player, the game and its narrator forms an important part of both the game's narrative and gameplay.

### ***Our Game***

**Genre:** Puzzle Adventure

**Sub-Genre/Elements:** Narrative Puzzle, Tile-Based Puzzle, Meta-Fiction

Our game primarily falls within the **puzzle genre**, as its main gameplay objective is to solve environmental puzzles in order to progress through the game. The player navigates a tile-based grid and must use the relationship between the **Normal mode** Map and **Safe mode** Map to overcome obstacles and reach the endpoint of each level. The map-switching mechanic therefore forms the central puzzle-solving system rather than simply being an additional feature, while the tile-based form of the game environment forms the actual “puzzle space”.

The game also contains elements of the **adventure genre**, particularly through its narrative progression and exploration of different game environments. However, unlike *The Silent Age* and *There Is No Game*, where puzzle-solving is contained within a broader point-and-click

adventure structure, our game uses puzzle-solving and tile-based movement as its primary gameplay.

The game also incorporates **meta-fictional** elements inspired by *There Is No Game: Wrong Dimension*. The Virus is aware of the player's actions (only within Normal Mode) and actively interferes with the game world by changing pathways, obstacles, layouts and mechanics. This creates a relationship between the player and the game system similar to the antagonistic relationship between the player and narrator in *There Is No Game*.

The game's genre is therefore derived from the combination of the genres and elements found in the cloned games. The adventure elements are informed by both *The Silent Age* and *There Is No Game*, while the game's puzzle focus is influenced by the environmental and logical puzzles found in both titles. The tile-based puzzle structure and map-switching system adapt the two-world puzzle concept of *The Silent Age* into a different gameplay format, while the meta-fictional Virus adapts the self-aware and antagonistic game system of *There Is No Game*. These elements are combined to create a more puzzle-focused adventure game with its own distinct gameplay and narrative identity.

## **Game Interrogation**

### **Core Game Question**

The core idea behind the development of this game is investigating how actively subverting player expectations and understanding of game mechanics and solutions affect a player's gameplay engagement and overall decision-making within a game.

### **Hypothesis**

*To what extent does an antagonistic narrative game element, The Virus, establish player expectations about how game mechanics and puzzles function, and how does its deliberate subversion of these expectations affect the player's experience and decision-making?*

### **Detailed Hypothesis Explanation**

In our game, The *Virus* is an antagonistic narrative game element that interacts directly with the player and actively interferes with their progression. While The Virus functions as an antagonist within the narrative, it also directly affects gameplay by changing the environment, obstacles, pathways and altering mechanics that the player uses to solve puzzles.

Game mechanics refer to the systems and actions available to the player that allow them to interact with and progress through the game. These include movement, map switching and the interactions between the Normal Map and Safe Mode Map. As players progress, they learn how these mechanics work and begin to form expectations about how the game will respond to their actions.

Player expectations are the assumptions players develop about how the game's mechanics and puzzles will behave based on their previous interactions with the game. For example, if a player learns that switching to the Safe Map allows them to overcome a particular type of obstacle, they may begin to expect that this relationship will remain consistent throughout the game.

The Virus is designed to subvert these expectations by deliberately interfering with the systems that the player has learned. The Virus may alter pathways, introduce new obstacles, change map layouts or modify how mechanics behave. This means that strategies which were previously successful may no longer work, forcing the player to reconsider their understanding of the game's systems and adapt their approach to solving puzzles.

The purpose of this project is therefore to investigate how players respond when their established expectations of game mechanics and puzzle-solving are deliberately disrupted. In particular, we are interested in whether this subversion changes the player's decision-making, encourages experimentation and adaptation, and affects their overall experience of the game.

This hypothesis will heavily be tested and investigated through playtesting and player feedback. Players can be observed as they encounter mechanics that initially behave consistently and establish expectations, followed by puzzles where The Virus deliberately subverts those expectations. Their reactions, problem-solving behaviour and decision-making can then be recorded through observation, questionnaires or interviews. Comparing player responses before and after their expectations are subverted can provide evidence of how this design approach affects the player's experience and approach to solving puzzles.

## **Design Goals**

### **1. Establish a Reliable Gameplay Foundation**

Create a gameplay loop in which the player develops a baseline understanding of the game's mechanics, conventions and systems before The Virus begins to subvert their expectations. Core rules that are necessary for understanding and navigating the game should remain consistent, allowing the player to distinguish between the game's established rules and deliberate interference caused by The Virus. This foundation should prevent the player from feeling that the game is arbitrary, unfair or excessively frustrating/confusing when mechanics are subverted.

### **2. Deliberately Subvert Player Expectations**

Create narrative beats, Virus mechanics and puzzle sections that intentionally challenge expectations that players have developed through previous interactions with the game. Once a mechanic or puzzle convention has been established, The Virus should be able to interfere with it through intentionally confusing but logical alterations. These changes should be intentional and recognisable as the actions of The Virus rather than appearing to be inconsistent/glitchy game design.

### **3. Encourage Player Adaptation and Experimentation**

Design puzzles that require players to reconsider their existing understanding of the game's mechanics when The Virus interferes with them. Subversion should encourage players to experiment with different approaches, test the boundaries of the game's systems and adapt their strategies rather than simply preventing progress. The player's ability to learn, adapt and develop new solutions should therefore be central to progression.

### **4. Seamlessly Integrate Narrative and Gameplay**

Ensure that The Virus's role as a narrative antagonist is directly connected to its gameplay actions. The Virus should communicate with the player and establish its personality through dialogue and narrative interactions while simultaneously affecting the puzzles and game world. This connection should make the Virus's interference feel like an intentional part of the narrative rather than a separate gameplay mechanic.

### **5. Create Meaningful Player Reactions**

Design the Virus's interventions to produce observable changes in how players approach the game. The goal is for players to experience reactions such as surprise, uncertainty, frustration, curiosity or increased experimentation when their expectations are subverted, while still feeling that the puzzles are fair and solvable. These reactions will allow the effectiveness of the game's central design concept to be evaluated through playtesting.

## Core Gameplay Loop

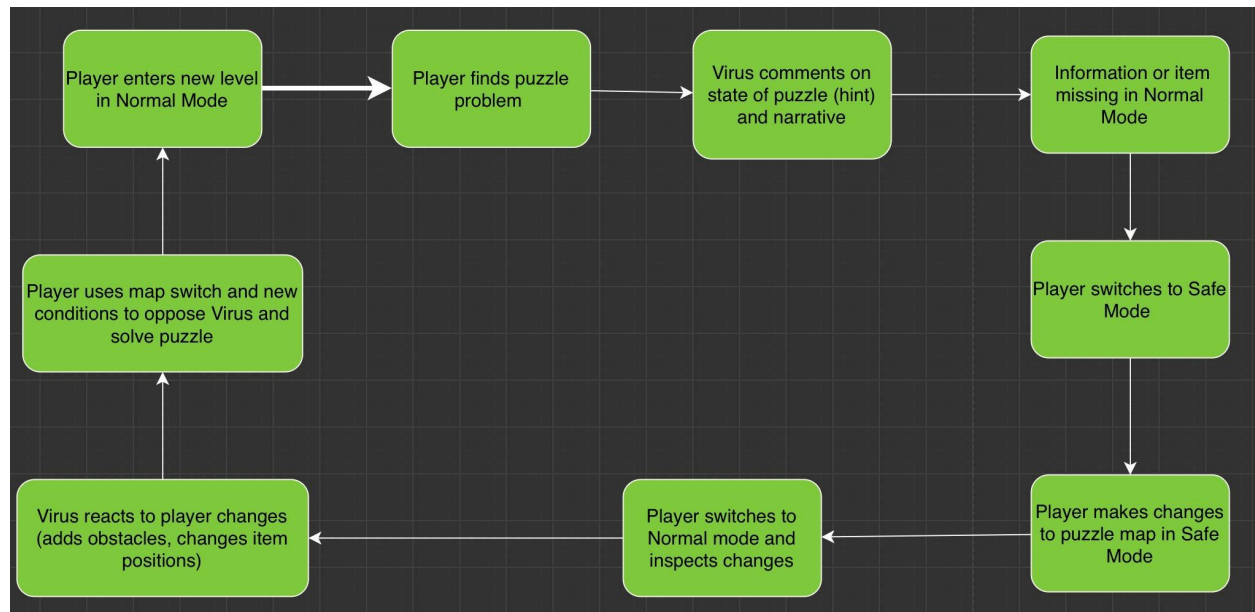


Figure 3: Preliminary core gameplay loop for each level.

## Systems and Mechanics

### **Mode Switching (Time Travel mechanic)**

The game will be played in two different modes, safe mode and normal mode. In normal mode the player will have to complete puzzles, while the player can get parts of the puzzle solution from safe mode, but can't complete the puzzle in safe mode.

There is an antagonist to the player, called The Virus, in normal mode which cannot affect the player in safe mode. This antagonistic Virus will eventually 'corrupt' normal mode by changing puzzles on the map whilst the player is playing and engaging with the world.

### **Normal/Corrupted Mode**

In the normal mode, the player will be able to complete the puzzle, but they are constantly getting opposed by The Virus. There will be some corrupted parts of the game which cannot be accessed in normal mode due to The Virus.

In normal mode the player will have access to all of the mechanics that do not get corrupted by The Virus.

## **Safe Mode**

In safe mode the player will not be able to complete the puzzle, but they will find some of the puzzle's solution in safe mode, that were corrupted by The Virus. This forces the player to switch to safe mode to get some solutions for the puzzles.

The player's mechanics will be limited in safe mode and the player cannot beat the level which incentivises the player to switch back to normal mode. An example of these limitations can be that the player can only hold one item while in safe mode.

## **The Virus**

The virus is the main antagonist stopping the player from progressing and beating the game. The virus can only affect the player and the game in normal mode, which makes safe mode a safe place for the player to be.

The Virus has different ways of opposing the player which can be seen in the following list:

- Removal of mechanics
  - The Virus can remove a mechanic from the player preventing them from using that mechanic.
- Adding of obstacles
  - The Virus can corrupt game elements to make it impossible for the player to pass in normal mode.
- Setting Traps
  - The Virus can set traps on specific tiles to cause a game over for the player.
- Changing Element Positions
  - The Virus can change the position of different game elements.
- Corrupting information
  - The Virus can corrupt the information of the player in order to hinder their progress.

## **System Interaction**

Both systems are mainly narrative driven systems where both are used in order to progress the story of the game. The Mode Switch system is used by the player to be able to fight against The Virus system. This means that the Virus system creates problems for the player while the Mode Switch system is a partial solution to it.

## **Gameplay Actions and Challenges**

### **Allowed Actions**

- Grid Movement: The player is allowed to move on a grid with WASD or Arrow Keys.

- Map Switching: The player is allowed to switch from the normal map to the corrupted map with Spacebar.
- Inventory: The player can open their inventory with BUTTON, The player can drop items from their inventory with BUTTON, The player can swap items in inventory slots with BUTTON.
- Interact: The player can interact with different elements in the game with BUTTON, this includes picking up items.

## Challenges

- Overall puzzle sections (**Overtime, explain what actual puzzles are like**):
  - **Moveable items**
  - **Inventory logic puzzles**
  - **Items like keys and locks which need to be fetched**
  - **Cause and effect puzzles which change the Normal mode puzzle layout when player makes a change in Safe Mode**
- The added challenge of Virus changing puzzle/ adding obstacles which adds difficulty:
  - **Virus switching positions of key puzzle items**
  - **Virus taking away or limiting certain player mechanics so the player has to rethink the solution.**

## **\* Design Process**

### **Milestone 1 Iterative Process**

#### **Coding Process**

Explain here

When making the game different problems need to be solved while trying to make the game which the group wants to make. These problems then get solved with the code, where the code is coded in a way that follows the rules set out in the project plan document.

If new problems get found during the development of the game the code either gets changed or new scripts get added to solve the problem.

(How Code is decided)(How it is done)(What causes parts of the code to change)

#### **Level Design Process**

Explain here

(EXplain how level developed over time), (Explain how connection between 2 systems was established through level 2), (Explain how level needed to have a “perceived solution” by player before the virus flips things around), (Pictures of development overtime)

## **Narrative Process**

Explain Here

# Story (**Work in progress**)

Game Developer- Player

Virus - Narrator

The player is playtesting their game, finds a virus, then plays through their game while getting rid of the virus.

## End Goal

The final goal of the game will be to remove The Virus from the game.

## Setting

Normal Mode - This is the state of the player's game which has been affected by the virus.

Safe Mode - This is the state of the game the player switches to find means to debug and solve puzzles which get rid of the virus.

Relationship between the two: The player can affect things in SAFE mode which have direct/indirect effects on NORMAL mode, but any NORMAL mode changes **DO NOT** affect Safe Mode.

## Theme (**Complete once core gameplay loop is implemented**)

### Player (Game Developer)

Playtesting their game, knows all about the mechanics in the game wants to get rid of the player

Motivation (Why does the player want to get rid of the Virus?)

So that the player can publish their game, without a virus.

Appearance (How will the player be seen in the game?)\*

### Virus

Motivation (Why does the virus want to stop the player?)

The Virus is a computer virus and was made to antagonize the player. It has no motivation to do so it is just doing what it was coded to do.

## Appearance (How will the virus be shown in game?)

The Virus will be represented by a mouse cursor, where the player can see what the Virus is currently doing through where the mouse cursor is.

(Still need to figure out how the virus is seen when the player completes the goal.)

## What is the Narrator (In terms of the story)

The Virus is a computer Virus affecting the player's code. This, in turn, affects the player's game by adding "lines of code" or "changes" which introduce obstacles/challenges in the game.

End Goal - Results in the virus being removed.

Motivation - Why is the player completing these puzzles?

History - How did the player get there? How does their past tie into their motivation?

## Levels ( **Work in progress - Complete once fully planned out\***)

### Level 1 - **Tutorialization**

No virus only introduction of player and mechanics

### Level 2 - **Introduction of Virus Mechanics**

Start of seeing the virus

### Level 3 - **Full Virus Opposition**

Virus is in full effect

### Level 4 - **Gameplay and Narrative resolution**

The player overcomes the virus.

# **Bibliography**

## **Research**

## **Images**

Figure 1: Allred, A. (2012). *The Silent Age: A Reflective Critical Review*. Medium. Available at: <https://medium.com/@avaallred03/the-silent-age-a-reflective-critical-review-2500d654e26>

Figure 2: The Walkthrough King (2021) *There Is No Game: Wrong Dimension*. Available at: <https://www.walkthroughking.com/text/thereisnogamewd.aspx> (Accessed: 30 August 2026).

## **General stuff**

[https://store.steampowered.com/app/352520/The\\_Silent\\_Age/](https://store.steampowered.com/app/352520/The_Silent_Age/)  
[https://store.steampowered.com/app/1924720/Five\\_Nights\\_at\\_Freddys\\_Security\\_Breach\\_Ruin/](https://store.steampowered.com/app/1924720/Five_Nights_at_Freddys_Security_Breach_Ruin/)  
[https://store.steampowered.com/app/1240210/There\\_Is\\_No\\_Game\\_Wrong\\_Dimension/](https://store.steampowered.com/app/1240210/There_Is_No_Game_Wrong_Dimension/)

Free game game version.

[https://store.steampowered.com/app/1241700/There\\_Is\\_No\\_Game\\_Jam\\_Edition\\_2015/](https://store.steampowered.com/app/1241700/There_Is_No_Game_Jam_Edition_2015/)